



Bundesministerium
der Finanzen



PICTURING OUR ONCE-ONLY VISION



The Once-Only principle: towards a user-centric and agile public administration

German Federal Ministry of Finance

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The Once-Only principle: towards a user-centric and agile public administration

- In the 2021–2025 coalition agreement, the German government itself set the goal of introducing the Once-Only principle as quickly as possible and of standardising legal terms such as “income” (“Einkommen”).
- The Once-Only principle means that citizens and companies only need to submit certain information and documents once when applying for government and public services. With their consent, public authorities can then re-use and exchange the data with each other.
- The network “Once-Only: Marketplace and Data Matching” (Once-Only: Marktplatz und Datenmatching), initiated by the Federal Ministry of Finance, the Federal Chancellery, and the Land of Bremen, is working on solutions to implement this goal.
- The project brings together stakeholders from various government departments and levels and uses modern collaborative working methods, including design thinking, agile working, and design sprints.
- The project aims to eliminate bureaucratic hurdles and proves that administrative procedures don’t need to be complicated.

Introduction

In Germany there are more than 200 government and public services that require the applicant to enter information on “income” (“Einkommen”). Whenever they apply for a government service, citizens and companies have to re-enter the same or similar information again, which makes the application process unnecessarily complicated and burdensome. The “Once-Only” project aims to clarify the term “income”. It will work to harmonise the definitions of this term and develop solutions to simplify the complex bureaucratic structures. The guiding principle is that the data should do the hard work, and not citizens or companies.

The Once-Only principle

The intention of introducing “the **Once-Only principle** as soon as possible” was set out in the 2021–2025 coalition agreement and is now being put into practice by the “Once-Only” network. The network puts public authorities that already have certain data in contact with authorities that need the same data.

The **Once-Only principle** aims to ensure that citizens and companies only need to submit necessary information to public authorities once. If the persons or companies concerned give their consent, the data is shared between authorities, which are able to re-use the data for other purposes at a later date. Once-Only is a key objective of the Online Access Act (Onlinezugangsgesetz), the Register Modernisation Act (Registermodernisierungsgesetz) and the Single Digital Gateway Regulation (an EU regulation to create a single digital gateway for administrative procedures in the EU).

This objective was underscored by the decision of the Federal Chancellor and the heads of the Länder governments that was adopted on 8 December 2022 and the **decisions of the IT Planning Council** in 2021 and 2022.

The **IT Planning Council** is the central political steering body for the digitalisation of Germany’s public administration. It coordinates IT-related issues across Germany’s federal and state governments and manages the digitalisation of public administration at the federal level. It also adopts binding decisions.

One might assume that two public authorities requiring the same data would be able to share that data without any difficulty. In reality, however, the exchange of data between individual authorities is complicated by a variety of content-related, technical, legal and organisational hurdles. In order for the digital exchange and re-use of data within the public administration to succeed, based on the Once-Only principle, legal terms need to be uniform and **interoperability** of the data in the registers of the roughly 11,000 public authorities in Germany must be ensured.

Interoperability refers to the ability of different systems to connect for the purposes of exchanging data, for example.

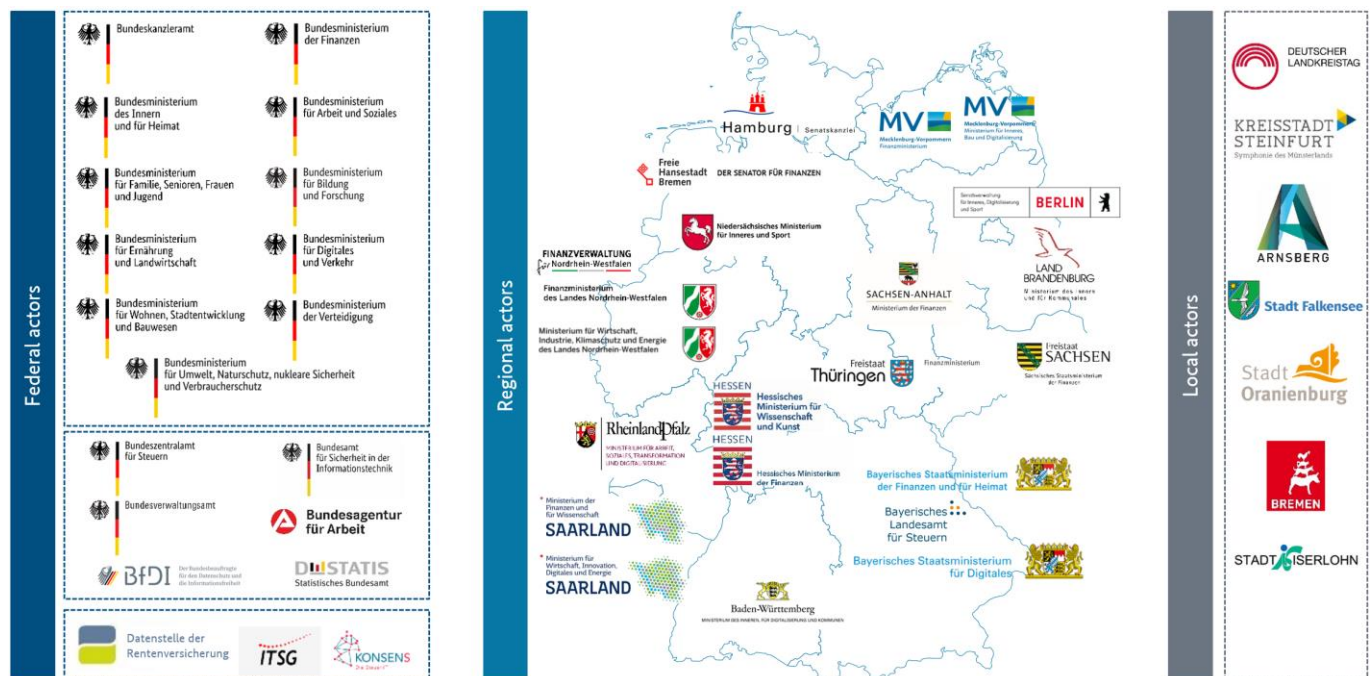
Benefits of the Once-Only principle

The Once-Only principle enables data to be exchanged between public authorities faster and more effectively. This significantly reduces the administrative burden: already available data and documents don't need to be checked again as they have already been checked by another public authority. This minimises error rates and prevents false information from being provided. Improving the exchange of data also contributes to closer cooperation between public authorities to ensure that citizens receive the services and benefits to which they are entitled.

This makes it much easier for citizens and companies to access government services. There is no need for them to re-enter information and resubmit documents since authorities are able to access the information and the documents from other authorities. This saves them time, money, trips to public offices and, above all, unnecessary stress.

An inter-departmental network

The Once-Only principle only works if public authorities work together. This is why the Federal Ministry of Finance, the Federal Chancellery and the Land of Bremen initiated a network across various government departments and levels with experts from the federal and Land governments and from local authorities. The different strands of the network currently converge at the Federal Ministry of Finance, where the network's findings are organised and processed. The network brings together experts specialising in a range of areas including the enforcement of legal provisions, IT, data handling and specific government services (for instance parental allowance). It facilitates cooperation between those who develop legislation, those who are responsible for implementing the legislation and those who develop the associated IT solutions for the implementation. Over 30 authorities and entities are actively involved in the network, showing that there is an enormous demand for solutions aimed at re-using data and simplifying bureaucratic procedures.



[Figure 1: An inter-departmental network. Source: Federal Finance Ministry]

Network members meet regularly in person and in interactive online formats to develop creative solutions to the specific challenges of implementing the Once-Only principle. Different perspectives, a broad range of experiences and interdisciplinary expertise are brought together and shared at these meetings. Close and non-hierarchical collaboration minimises silo mentalities and competitive mindsets.

The collaboration approach is user-centric: personal interviews are conducted with citizens and companies so that their perspectives are heard and taken into account. The project team uses **agile working** methods and **design thinking** techniques to strengthen cooperation within the network and to ensure a win-win situation for everyone involved. Above all, the network provides an incentive for authorities to share data with each other.

Agile working focuses on self-organising teams, close communication, and a step-by-step approach. This enables the development of user-centric services within a short space of time. Existing deficiencies can be identified and rectified at an early stage with the help of user feedback. Agile project management fosters a high degree of flexibility, the ability to learn and adapt, creativity and innovation as well as non-hierarchical working.

Design thinking is a working method used to develop creative solutions to practical problems, where the focus is always on the wishes and needs of users.

Transparency, the direct transfer of knowledge and open feedback mean that everyone involved in the network is always learning from each other. Successes and the achievement of interim targets are actively communicated within the network. In this way, the project is successfully putting into action the coalition agreement's objective of establishing agile project teams and innovation units across ministries and authorities and of modernising and streamlining the public administration.

Research and analysis of income data

So far, the "Once-Only" project has focused primarily on income data. In collaboration with the network, it was possible to identify over 200 **government services** for which data on income is relevant. The amount of a government service, such as a grant or benefit payment, is usually determined based on the applicant's level of income. However, the income and expenditures that are relevant differ from service to service.

Important **government services** include housing benefit (*Wohngeld*), citizen's benefit (*Bürgergeld*), grants and loans for students and apprentices (BAföG) and survivor's pensions (*Hinterbliebenenrente*). For many citizens, the contributions they receive significantly affect their quality of life.

Across government services there is no uniform legal definition of the term "income". For example, income tax (*Einkommensteuer*) return asks for seven types of income, while the application for parental allowance (*Elterngeld*) does not include rental income as possible source of income.

To better understand these inconsistencies between government services, the project team researched and analysed ten government services: BAföG, citizen's benefit, citizen's benefit top-up (*Bürgergeld-Aufstocker*), parental allowance, housing benefit, advance on child maintenance to single parents (*Unterhaltsvorschuss*), survivor's pension, sick pay (*Krankengeld*), short-time work benefit (*Kurzarbeitergeld*) and maternity benefit (*Mutterschaftsgeld*).

Research results: income components in ten government services

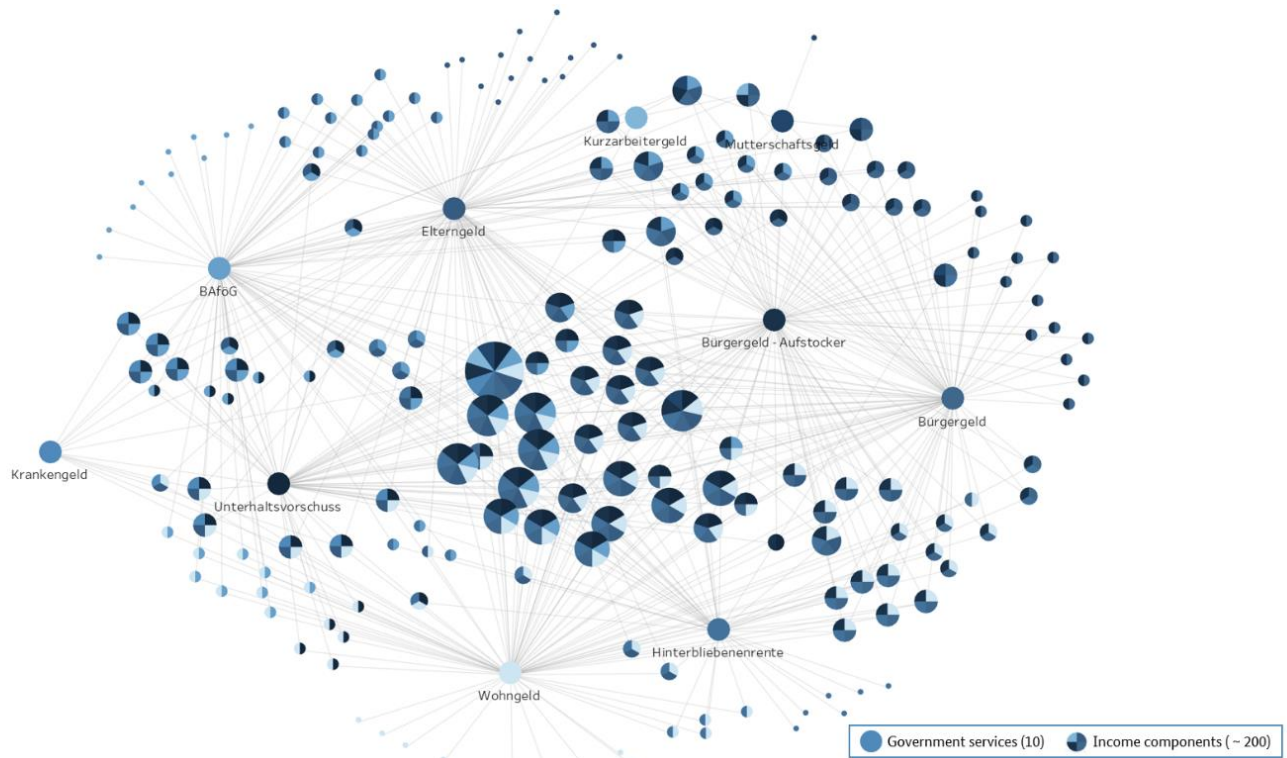
In every government service, the legal term "income" refers to different sources of income, so-called "income components". Altogether, the ten services that were analysed include more than 200 different income components. The project team identified the legal basis for each of these income components.

Of the 200 income components (i.e. sources of income that an applicant has to communicate) from the ten analysed services:

- 44 income components are asked in one single service,
- 157 income components are asked in several services,
- and 29 income elements are asked in at least five services.

The analysis reveals that:

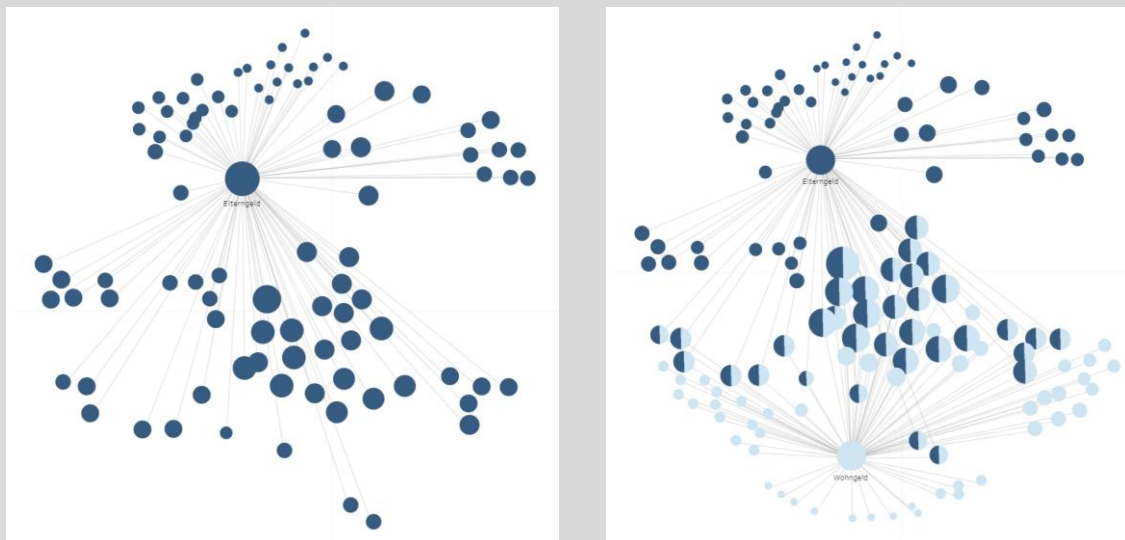
- Many individual components are required for multiple government services and hence offer potential for a re-use of data.
- One of the components that is included in every government service is income from employment (*Einkünfte aus nichtselbstständiger Arbeit*) pursuant to section 19 of the German Income Tax Act.



[Figure 2: Around 200 income components in ten government services. Source: Federal Finance Ministry]

Overlap of income components in the services parental allowance and housing benefit

A comparison of the services parental allowance and housing benefit reveals an overlap of approximately 25%. Of the 141 income components in these two government services, 36 income components occur in both parental allowance and housing benefit.

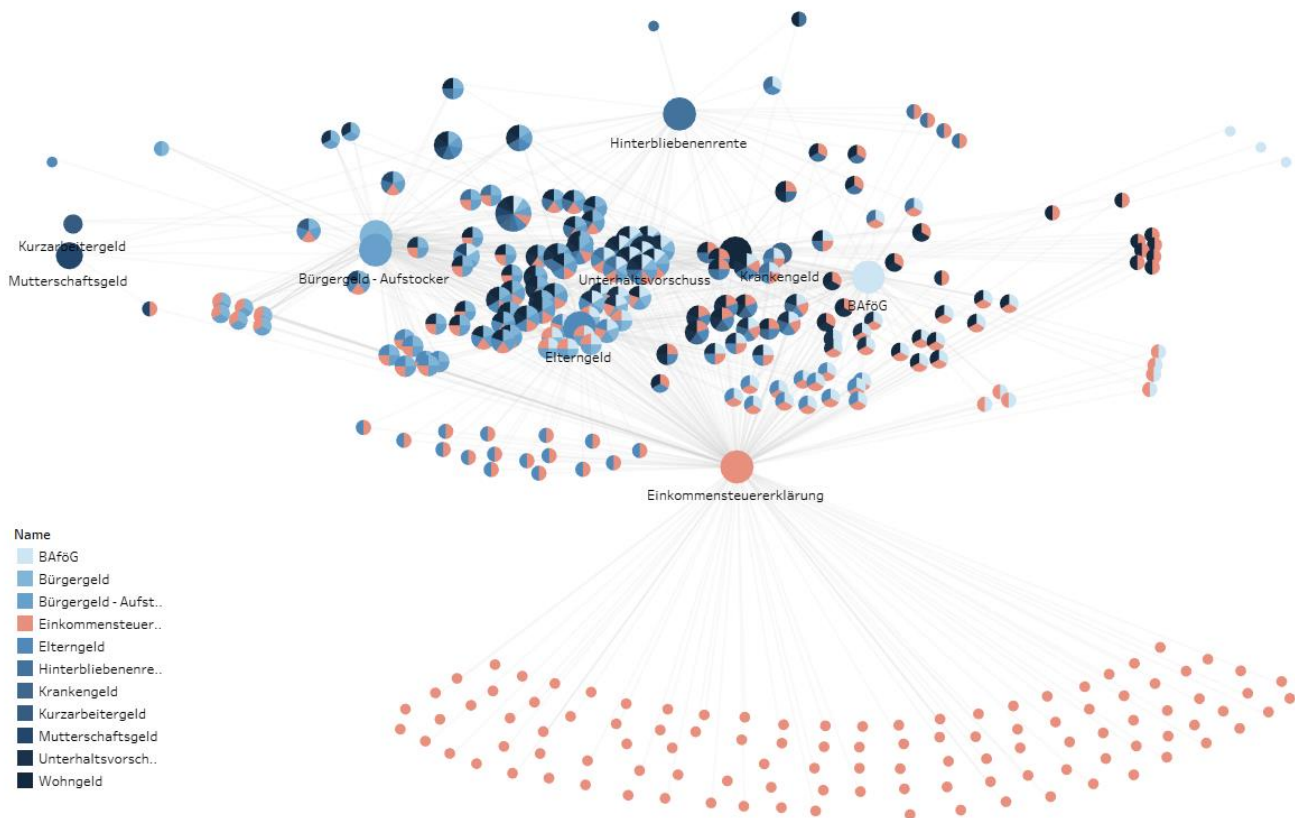


[Figures 3.1 and 3.2.: Overlap of income components in the government services parental allowance and housing benefit. Source: Federal Finance Ministry]

Research results: income components and income tax return

The above-mentioned ten government services were also compared to the German income tax return. Approximately 300 income components were found altogether. The income tax return contains all but 15 of the income components found in the

ten analysed government services. This shows that income tax returns result in a lot of data that could also be used by other authorities.



[Figure 4: Overlap between the income components in the ten government services and income tax return data. Source: Federal Finance Ministry]

In practice, the use of already available data is hindered by a variety of factors. For example, some government services have a different assessment period than the assessment period for determining income tax. For parental allowance, for example, the previous 12 months' income is decisive rather than income from the last calendar year, as is the case for income tax. It needs to be considered to what extent it is possible to standardise the assessment period of different services. Although this would simplify the procedures, it needs to be weighed against ensuring that the services are properly targeted and equitable.

Research results: existing data-exchange systems

The project team found 140 exchanges between institutions that already share information on income digitally with one another. Thirty-three institutions that provide data and 22 institutions that receive data are involved in this exchange of data.

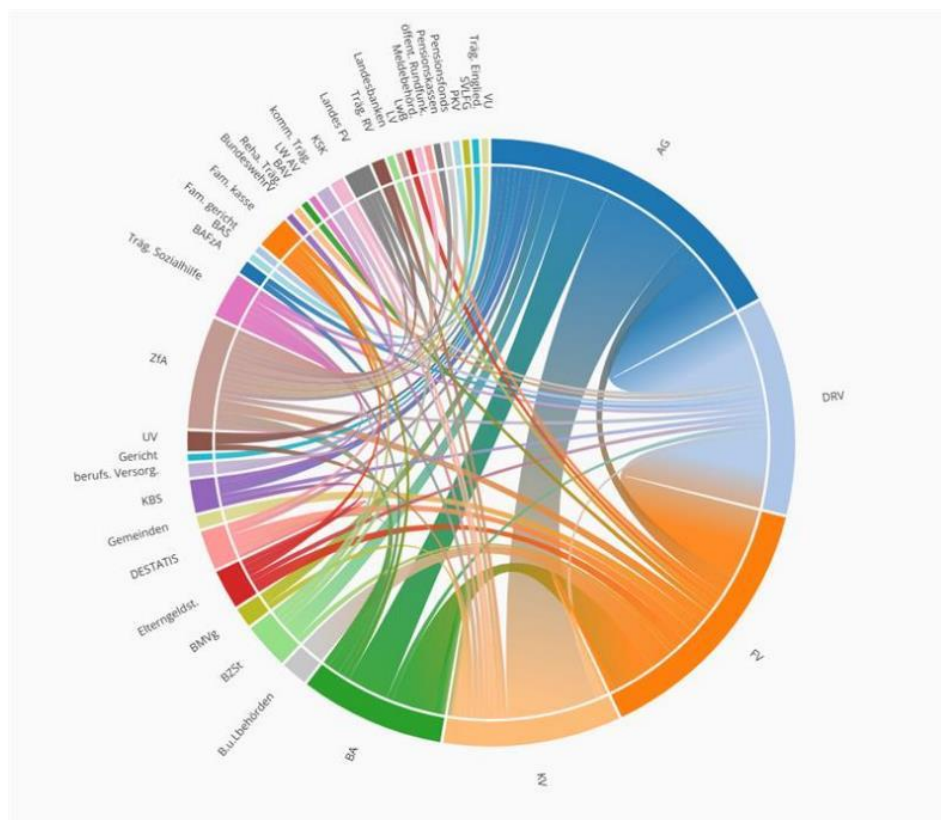
The analysis of these data-exchange systems highlighted other possibilities for the introduction of the Once-Only principle. Two frequently requested data collections are already being shared between authorities:

- An exchange of data on income from employment is shared using the **rvBEA** system.
- A lot of data on income replacement benefits is shared via **GKVnet**.

Since the exchanged data is also needed for other government services, these two systems provide a starting point for swiftly enabling the data to also be used in other contexts.

rvBEA is a retrieval system that facilitates the electronic exchange of data between employers and the pension insurance funds.

GKVnet is an application for the secure and fast exchange of data in the area of healthcare and social services.



[Figure 5: Existing data-exchange systems for income data. Source: Federal Finance Ministry]

Acronyms	
AG	Arbeitgeber (employer)
berufs. Versorg.	Berufsständischen Versorgungseinrichtungen (pension institutions for the free professions)
BAV	Betriebsrentenkassen (occupational pension funds)
B.u.Lbehörden	Bundes- und Landesbehörde (federal and Land authorities)
BA	Bundesagentur für Arbeit (Federal Employment Agency)
BAFzA	Bundesamt für Familie und zivilgesellschaftliche Aufgabe (Federal Office of Family Affairs and Civil Society Functions)
BAS	Bundesamt für Soziale Sicherung (Federal Office for Social Security)
BMVg	Bundesministerium der Verteidigung (Federal Ministry of Defence)
BundeswehrV	Bundeswehrverwaltung (Bundeswehr administration)
BZSt	Bundeszentralamt für Steuern (Federal Central Tax Office)
DESTATIS	Statistisches Bundesamt (Federal Statistical Office)
DRV	Deutsche Rentenversicherung (German statutory pension scheme)
Elterngeldst.	Elterngeldstelle (Parental allowance office)
Fam. gericht	Familiengericht (Family court)
Fam. kasse	Familienkasse (Child benefit disbursement office)
FV	Finanzverwaltung (Revenue administration)
Gemeinden	Municipalities
Gericht	Court
LW AV	Gesamtverband der landwirtschaftlichen Alterskassen (association of agricultural pension funds)
KBS	Knappschaft-Bahn-See (German pension insurance institute for railway and maritime workers)
komm. Träg.	Kommunale Träger (local authority providers)
KV	Krankenkasse (health insurance fund)
KSK	Künstlersozialkasse (Artists Social Security Fund)
Landesbanken	Regional banks
Landes FV	Landesfinanzverwaltung (Land revenue administration)
SVLFG	Landwirtschaftliche Alterskasse (agricultural pension fund)
LwB	Landwirtschaftsbehörde (agricultural authority)
LV	Lebensversicherer (life insurer)
öffent. Rundfunk.	Öffentliche Rundfunkanstalten (public service broadcasters)
Pensionskassen	Pension funds
PKV	Private Krankenversicherung (private health insurance)
Reha. Träg.	Rehabilitationsträger (rehabilitation authorities)
DESTATIS	Statistisches Bundesamt (Federal Statistical Office)
Träg. Einglied.	Träger der Eingliederungshilfe (integration assistance providers)
Träg. RV	Träger der Rentenversicherung (pension providers)
Träg. Sozialhilfe	Träger der Sozialhilfe (social welfare providers)
UV	Unfallversicherungsträger (accident insurance providers)
VU	Versicherungsunternehmen (insurance companies)
Zahlst. VB	Zahlstellen der Versorgungsbezüge (pension payment offices)
ZfA	Zentrale Zulagenstelle für Altersvermögen (central allowance office for retirement assets)

Implementation of Once-Only principle use cases

Based on the research results, the project team is working on evidence-based use cases to generate practical insights to support the introduction of the Once-Only principle. The network connects potential data providers and data users, and tests and evaluates the digital exchange of data on income between authorities. The project team is providing the impetus, advice, and support for the implementation of data sharing. Together, solutions to content-related, technical, legal, and organisational interoperability issues are being developed. The use cases are being tested in **design sprints**.

In a **design sprint**, a basic approach (design) is developed within a short space of time. Usually, a design sprint lasts just a few weeks. The advantage of a design sprint is the efficient and iterative collaboration between different interdisciplinary teams within the public administration. Ideas can be developed quickly, put into practice, and tested with users.

The focus of the current use cases is on income components which are required for many government services and for which data-exchange systems already exist. One use case example is the digital application for parental allowance used in the *Land of Bremen*: “Einfache Leistungen für Eltern” (“simple services for parents”). Via an interface to the applicant’s pension insurance provider, employers are able to automatically transmit information on employment income to the competent authority if the person applying for the parental allowance provides their consent. Other income components are also needed for parental allowance. These could be incorporated into the digital process relatively easily.

The use cases provide evidence that the Once-Only principle works and that it is possible for data on income to be exchanged between authorities. Updates and details on successful use cases are shared within the “Once-Only” network. These positive examples motivate and enable others to implement their own use cases.

Outlook

The further implementation of the Once-Only principle requires a harmonisation of key legal terms such as the legal term “income”. This can be achieved with a law that clearly defines legal terms. In addition, a data repository is needed for the semantic and technical interoperability of data. The data repository records which legal terms are contained in which registers and specialised procedures according to which semantic and technical specifications. The administrative data information platform (*Verwaltungsdaten-Informationsplattform*), the register map (*Registerlandkarte*), the data atlas and the standards of the Coordination Office for IT Standards (*Koordinierungsstelle für IT-Standards*) form the basis of the repository. The “Once-Only” project promotes and supports the implementation of these recommendations. The network will be working on further, practical use cases in the coming months in order to gain more insights into the implementation of the Once-Only principle.

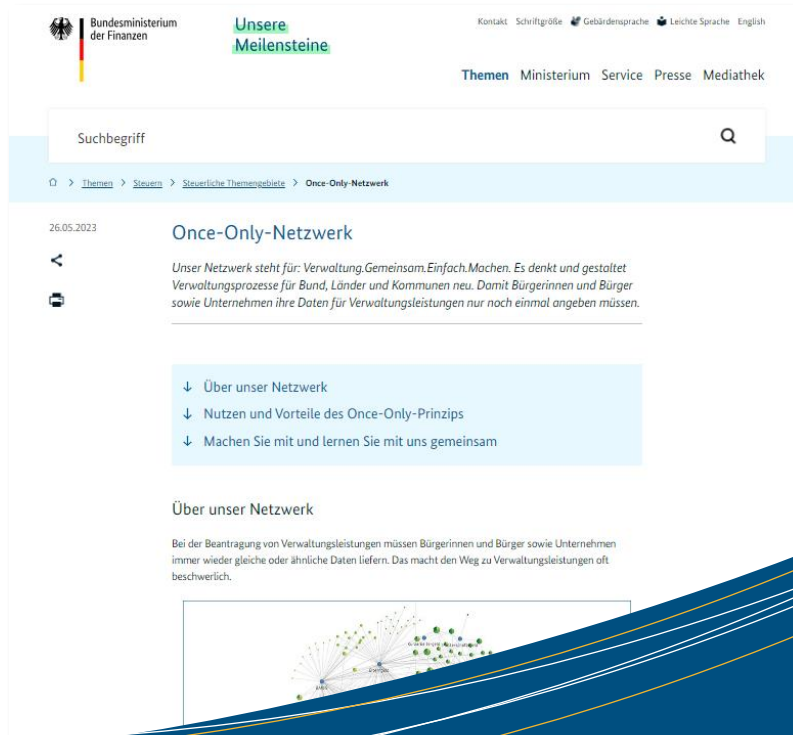
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Credits:

Cover picture: Pictures from a workshop, © Bundesministerium der Finanzen

More information on the “Once-Only” project can be found on the website of the Germany Federal Ministry of Finance (in German):

<https://www.bundesfinanzministerium.de/Content/DE/Standardartikel/Themen/Steuern/Steuerliche-Themengebiete/Once-Only/ueberblick.html>



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